

consider, but don't forget to factor in pet sitting services for when you're away too.

Estimate the monthly cost as best you can, then set aside that amount in preparation for all pet-related expenses. An average starting point is usually between \$500-\$700 per year for either a dog or cat, but remember, you will have a lot of one-time fees as well. A crate, initial checkup, spaying/neutering fee, litter boxes, and toys will add to that first-time yearly cost.

You'll want to consider having a pet Emergency Fund in place for those middle of the night vet visits that seem to happen at least once or twice during the life of your pet. You can always adjust the amount if needed, but the key is to just *start*!

ANNUAL PET EXPENSES:

Food: Dog \$120 | Cat \$145

Annual Exams: Dog \$235 | Cat \$130

Litter: Cat \$200

Toys and Treats: Dog \$55 | Cat \$25

License: Dog \$15

Pet Insurance: Dog \$225 | Cat \$175

Miscellaneous: Dog \$45 | Cat \$30

**numbers from the ASPCA*

2. ADOPT A MIXED BREED

Purebred fans might hate me for this, but I honestly believe mixed breeds are not only healthier in the long run (i.e., not as many vet bills), but they also cost less to buy upfront. Without getting into too much detail, the gene